Yosemite & the Eastern Sierra — Family road trip · Aug 2–7, 2027

Mon Aug 2 – Sat Aug 7, 2027 · Fresno → Oakhurst (3 nights) → Tioga Road → Convict Lake (2 nights) → Kings Beach, Lake Tahoe

Key Contacts

Stays

Yosemite Pink Cottage
Oakhurst, CA (exact address after booking) · https://www.airbnb.com/rooms/1389296323448414507

Convict Lake Resort — Spa Cabin
2000 Convict Lake Rd, Mammoth Lakes, CA 93546 · 760-934-3800 · https://www.convictlake.com/

Brockway Springs condo, Kings Beach (Tahoe)
9200 Brockway Springs Dr, Kings Beach, CA 96143 · https://ghazal-tehrani.me/vacations/tahoe

Getting around

Fresno Yosemite International Airport (FAT)
5175 E Clinton Way, Fresno, CA 93727 · https://flyfresno.com/ground-transportation/

Reno-Tahoe International Airport (RNO)
2001 E Plumb Ln, Reno, NV 89502 · https://www.renoairport.com/

Reds Meadow Shuttle (Mammoth Adventure Center)
Mammoth Mountain Main Lodge, 10001 Minaret Rd, Mammoth Lakes, CA 93546 · https://www.mammothmountain.com/things-to-do/activities/reds-meadow-shuttle

Convict Lake Marina
2000 Convict Lake Rd, Mammoth Lakes, CA 93546 · 760-934-3800 · https://www.convictlake.com/marina-2/

Restaurants (in order)

Sam's Italian Deli & Market
2415 N First St, Fresno, CA 93703 · 559-229-9346 · https://samsitaliandeli.com/

Mountain Oaks Cafe
40282 CA-41 Unit 9, Oakhurst, CA 93644 · 559-683-1120

Judy's Donuts
40444 CA-41, Oakhurst, CA 93644 · 559-683-2095

Curry Village Pizza Deck
9010 Curry Village Dr, Yosemite Valley, CA 95389 · 209-372-8333 · https://www.travelyosemite.com/dining/curry-village-dining/

Elderberry House (Château du Sureau)
48688 Victoria Ln, Oakhurst, CA 93644 · 559-683-6800 · https://www.chateausureau.com/ernas-elderberry-house-restaurant/

Bee's Bakery Cafe
40250 Junction Dr, Oakhurst, CA 93644 · 559-683-2393 · https://beesbakerycafe.com/

Smokehouse 41 BBQ
40713 CA-41, Oakhurst, CA 93644 · 559-642-2271 · https://smokehouse41.com/

Whoa Nellie Deli
22 Vista Point Dr, Lee Vining, CA 93541 · 760-647-1088 · https://www.whoanelliedeli.com/

Restaurant at Convict Lake
2000 Convict Lake Rd, Mammoth Lakes, CA 93546 · 760-934-3800 · https://www.convictlake.com/fine-dining/

The Stove
644 Old Mammoth Rd, Mammoth Lakes, CA 93546 · 760-934-2821

Stellar Brew & Natural Cafe
3280 Main St, Mammoth Lakes, CA 93546 · 760-924-3559 · https://stellarbrew.life/

Skadi
3228 Main St, Mammoth Lakes, CA 93546 · 760-914-0962 · https://www.skadirestaurant.com/

Silver Lake Cafe (Silver Lake Resort)
6957 CA-158, June Lake, CA 93529 · 760-648-7525 · https://www.silverlakeresort.net/

Coachwhip Cafe
110411 US-395, Coleville, CA 96107 · 760-616-4772

Parks & sights

Mariposa Grove of Giant Sequoias
Mariposa Grove Welcome Plaza, Wawona Rd, Yosemite National Park, CA 95389 · https://www.nps.gov/yose/planyourvisit/mg.htm

Mist Trail to Vernal Fall (Happy Isles)
Happy Isles Trailhead, Yosemite Valley, CA 95389 · https://www.nps.gov/yose/planyourvisit/vernalnevadatrail.htm

Bodie State Historic Park
Bodie State Historic Park, Hwy 270, Bridgeport, CA 93517 · 760-616-5040 · https://www.parks.ca.gov/?page_id=509

Rainbow Falls & Devils Postpile
Devils Postpile National Monument, Mammoth Lakes, CA 93546 · https://www.nps.gov/depo/index.htm

Day-by-Day

Day 1 · Mon, Aug 2 · Travel day — Fly into Fresno, giant sequoias, settle into Oakhurst

~1 hr FAT → Oakhurst · 25 min to Mariposa Grove · Sleep: Yosemite Pink Cottage

- Fly DC → Fresno Yosemite International Airport (FAT). No nonstop from DC; aim to land by about 1 PM.
- Pick up the one-way rental at the terminal rental-car center (drop at RNO after Tahoe).
- 1:30 PM — Lunch: Sam's Italian Deli & Market — sandwiches and Italian deli counter, about 15 min from the airport.
- Alt lunch: Heirloom, farm-to-table in north Fresno, right on the CA-41 route.
- 2:30 PM — Drive about 1 hr up CA-41 to Oakhurst.
- 3:45 PM — Mariposa Grove of Giant Sequoias — park at the Welcome Plaza and take the free shuttle; walk the 2-mi Grizzly Giant loop. Last bus down was 8 PM in 2026.
- 6:30 PM — Check in at Yosemite Pink Cottage (Airbnb). Hot tub tonight; sauna is for the 13-year-old and up, short supervised sessions.
- 7:15 PM — Dinner: Mountain Oaks Cafe — chili verde, pozole, chowder; one of the few Oakhurst spots open Monday.

Day 2 · Tue, Aug 3 · Yosemite Valley — Mist Trail to Vernal Fall, then the Merced River

~1h30 each way Oakhurst ↔ Valley · Leave by 6:30 AM · Sleep: Yosemite Pink Cottage

- 6:20 AM — Donuts and coffee to go at Judy's Donuts.
- 7:50 AM — Tunnel View — the first view of the Valley; 10 minutes is enough.
- 8:30 AM — Mist Trail to Vernal Fall (Happy Isles) — 2.4 mi round trip, 1,000 ft of granite steps through the spray. Bring rain jackets; no permit needed for Vernal Fall.
- Alt: Easier version: turn around at the Vernal Fall footbridge (1.6 mi, 400 ft).
- 12:15 PM — Lunch: Curry Village Pizza Deck — the Valley’s best-rated food, steps from the trail.
- 1:30 PM — Lower Yosemite Fall Loop — flat 1-mi loop to the base of North America’s tallest waterfall.
- 2:30 PM — Swim and wade at Cathedral Beach (Merced River) with El Capitan overhead. NPS: only when the river is low and calm; never above a waterfall.
- Or Sentinel Beach (Merced River), calmer and shallower with picnic tables.
- Or swap the swim for Mirror Lake Trail — Half Dome reflections, though the lake can be low by August.
- 4:45 PM — Valley View (Gates of the Valley) on the drive out.
- 7:00 PM — Dinner splurge: Elderberry House (Château du Sureau) — seasonal tasting menu. Call to confirm kids are welcome.
- Alt: Casual swap: South Gate Brewing Co. (below the 4.5 bar, very kid-easy).

Day 3 · Wed, Aug 4 · Glacier Point Road — Taft Point, Sentinel Dome and Glacier Point, then a slow afternoon

~1h15 Oakhurst → Glacier Point Rd trailheads · Leave by 9:00 AM · Sleep: Yosemite Pink Cottage

- 8:00 AM — Breakfast at Bee's Bakery Cafe; order sandwiches to go for lunch.
- 10:15 AM — Taft Point & Sentinel Dome Trailhead — Taft Point first (2.2 mi): cliff-edge Fissures with 2,000-ft drops, so hold hands. Then Sentinel Dome (2 mi, 400 ft) for the 360° summit view.
- 1:00 PM — Picnic at Glacier Point, then Washburn Point for the side view of Vernal and Nevada falls.
- 3:30 PM — Back at the cottage: hot tub, sauna, nothing scheduled.
- 6:00 PM — Dinner: Smokehouse 41 BBQ — Oakhurst's favorite BBQ, Wed–Sun only, no reservations; go early.
- Alt: Treat: Reimer's Candies & Ice Cream for ice cream.
- Alt: Sunset instead: take a picnic dinner back up to Glacier Point for sunset (~8 PM) and skip Smokehouse (it's closed the rest of your Oakhurst nights).

Day 4 · Thu, Aug 5 · Tioga Road — Across the high country to Mono Lake and Convict Lake

~3h30 of driving before stops (Oakhurst → Lee Vining → Convict Lake) · Leave by 7:30 AM · Sleep: Convict Lake Resort — Spa Cabin

- 7:00 AM — Breakfast and picnic snacks to go from Bee's Bakery Cafe; check out of the cottage.
- 9:45 AM — Olmsted Point — the back side of Half Dome and a field of glacier boulders for scrambling (0.25-mi walk).
- 10:15 AM — Swim at Tenaya Lake (east beach) — cold, clear and sandy on the east end. No rentals here; kids under 13 need a PFD on any paddle craft.
- 11:45 AM — Pothole Dome — a 1-mi granite scramble with a Tuolumne Meadows view.
- Alt: Bigger option: Lembert Dome (~3 mi, 850 ft) — off the dome before the afternoon storms.
- Alt: Longer option: Elizabeth Lake (4.8 mi, 900 ft) to a lake under Unicorn Peak.
- Alt: Quick snack stop: Tuolumne Meadows Grill (seasonal; soft-serve).
- 12:45 PM — Over Tioga Pass (9,943 ft). Optional: Gaylor Lakes right at the pass — alpine lakes and old mine ruins.
- 1:30 PM — Late lunch: Whoa Nellie Deli — fish tacos and lobster taquitos at the gas station that became a legend.
- 3:00 PM — Mono Lake South Tufa — the 1-mi tufa-tower loop; kids are free.
- Alt: Add Panum Crater next door — a young volcanic crater rim walk (1.5 mi).
- 4:30 PM — Check in at Convict Lake Resort — Spa Cabin (about 40 min south). Ask for the spa cabin with its own outdoor hot tub.
- 6:30 PM — Dinner on site: Restaurant at Convict Lake — reserve ahead.

Day 5 · Fri, Aug 6 · Mammoth Lakes — Rainbow Falls and Devils Postpile, then paddle Convict Lake

~20 min Convict Lake → Mammoth; shuttle to Reds Meadow · Leave by 7:15 AM · Sleep: Convict Lake Resort — Spa Cabin

- 7:30 AM — Breakfast at The Stove.
- 8:30 AM — Reds Meadow Shuttle (Mammoth Adventure Center) from the Main Lodge to Reds Meadow.
- 9:15 AM — Rainbow Falls & Devils Postpile — the basalt columns, then 1.3 mi down to Rainbow Falls (101 ft, often with a rainbow in the spray). Little shade; bring water.
- 12:45 PM — Lunch in town: Stellar Brew & Natural Cafe — bowls, smoothies, sandwiches.
- 2:00 PM — Paddle at Convict Lake Marina — kayaks, pedal kayaks or SUPs (2-hr minimum; renter 18+). Then the flat 3-mi lake loop if legs are willing.
- Alt: Instead: Crystal Lake (Lake George) (3.2 mi, 685 ft) — Mammoth's best short hike.
- Or ride the Mammoth Panorama Gondola to the 11,053-ft summit (kids 12 and under free).
- Or a quick look at Hot Creek Geological Site — boiling turquoise pools, overlook only.
- 5:00 PM — Hot tub back at the cabin.
- 7:00 PM — Dinner: Skadi — Nordic-alpine, the best meal in Mammoth. Book ahead.

Day 6 · Sat, Aug 7 · Drive to Tahoe — June Lake breakfast, Bodie ghost town, north on 395 to Lake Tahoe

~4h30–5 hr of driving (Convict Lake → Bodie → Kings Beach) · Leave by 7:30 AM · Sleep: Brockway Springs condo, Kings Beach (Tahoe)

- 7:30 AM — Check out of Convict Lake Resort — Spa Cabin; drive the June Lake Loop (CA-158).
- 8:15 AM — Breakfast at Silver Lake Cafe (Silver Lake Resort) on Silver Lake.
- Alt: Quick swim stop: June Lake Beach ($10/vehicle) or a walk to Parker Lake.
- Alt: Coffee-only swap: Latte Da Coffee Cafe in Lee Vining.
- 10:30 AM — Bodie State Historic Park — a gold-rush town left as it was in the 1940s; 1.5–2 hrs. $8 adults, $5 ages 4–17.
- 12:45 PM — Soak at Travertine Hot Springs — free natural travertine pools a 1-min walk from the car. Heads-up: clothing-optional bathers are common. Skip it if that's a no.
- 1:45 PM — Lunch: Coachwhip Cafe in Coleville — tri-tip sandwiches and quiche (Thu–Sun).
- Or Walker Burger a few minutes north — classic burger stand with outdoor tables.
- 4:45 PM — Arrive Brockway Springs condo, Kings Beach (Tahoe) in Kings Beach. The Tahoe page picks up from here.